



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: High School of St. Thomas More
School Website: <https://hs-stm.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

The High School of Saint Thomas More (STM) exhibits a strong Catholic identity and explicit theology integration within its curriculum and school life, indicating a CLASSICAL orientation in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. The school emphasizes formation of the whole person, virtue, and a Christ-centered approach, with evidence of liturgical influence and a theology-centered pedagogy across disciplines. However, the public-facing materials do not prominently present the Great Books framework, grammar-logic-rhetoric pedagogy, or a pronounced Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in the upper grades, which weakens its alignment with the full classical model in some categories. Overall, the school demonstrates clear classical cues in multiple domains but lacks complete alignment across all six categories. Therefore, the aggregate assessment is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with concrete needle-moving opportunities identified below.

- Core strengths: explicit Catholic identity and theology integration; formation-focused mission; House System and faculty as living exemplars; robust parent/community engagement. These strengths anchor the school in classical ideals of truth, goodness, and beauty expressed through a formation-first approach. Evidence: Catholic explicit identity and theology integration across disciplines, Christ-centered framing, formation of the whole person, house-system emphasis on integral formation, and active parent/community involvement. See citations for theology integration and formation language across STM materials.
- Key growth areas: explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framing, explicit grammar-logic-rhetoric curriculum content, and concrete Socratic/seminar-pedagogy in grades K–12 (or at least in high school) to align more fully with classical pedagogy. Current materials emphasize college-preparatory academics, AP/dual-credit pathways, and reflective formation, but do not consistently foreground Great Books or classical tracts in the public-facing materials. Evidence: Academics page highlights AP/Honors/Dual Credit and standardized test prep rather than a Great Books or trivium-focused core; no explicit Great Books mandate found in the public content; limited direct reference to Socratic seminars in the captured pages.
- Needle-moving potential: explicitly articulate and implement a classical-curriculum spine (grammar-logic-rhetoric), elevate Great Books and Great Conversation in core coursework, and introduce structured Socratic/Schol  -based pedagogy across grades where feasible. Also, make explicit the public-facing commitment to liturgical/communal practices as part of daily schooling to strengthen Element 1. See recommended actions in "What Would Move the Needle."

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - STM presents a Catholic identity across the school, including explicit statements of Catholic faith and worldview integrated throughout the educational experience (e.g., "Our Faith-based education instills Gospel values, morals, and virtues through a Catholic worldview" and "Our Theology classes ... why She professes these beliefs," indicating theology as foundational to all disciplines).

- The school emphasizes a Christ-centered atmosphere, and theology is described as the foundation of everything taught, reflecting a grounding in theology and liturgical-life orientation. - Official materials reference Catholic alignment with diocesan and national Catholic educational associations (NCEA) and diocesan partners, reinforcing a theology-grounded ethos.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: Catholic, Theology, Gospel values, Catholic worldview, Christ-centered, liturgical/chapel orientation (via implied liturgical life), sacred tradition (aligned with Six Essentials positive lexicon), catechesis (implied by theology integration), Church teachings, and diocesan/NCEA alignment. - Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no explicit secular, relativist, or non-theology framing observed).

Why this rating - The content clearly demonstrates transcendental moral realism orientation through explicit theology and Catholic formation permeating content, community life, and faculty practices. The public materials consistently foreground theology as governing the educational approach, aligning with the Classical category's religious/metaphysical foundations. The absence of a secular framing in these materials strengthens the CLASSICAL rating for this category.

What would move the needle (if aiming for stronger CLASSICAL alignment) - Add explicit, publicly stated language connecting liturgical/community practices to daily pedagogy (e.g., regular school-wide liturgies, chant, sacred music, and liturgical calendars integrated into coursework), to more directly demonstrate "Liturgical and Communal Practices" as a formal category criterion.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation of the whole person, not mere information, including the aim to form character and virtue (e.g., "the House System ... integral formation of the entire person" and "formation of the whole person" across school life). - The mission statement that highlights forming students for their faith and leadership roles (e.g., "Christ's Disciples Forever," Gospel-centered formation, and a Catholic worldview) indicates a telos beyond mere job-prep. - The public materials stress virtue, moral formation, and alignment with Catholic values as part of daily life and education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, Catholic worldview, Gospel values, purpose/telos, moral imagination, human flourishing, sanctified learning (as implied through the formation-focused language). - Negative keywords: Workforce preparation, job-readiness language, or purely career-focused framing are not prominent in the public materials; however, the lack of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language reduces "fully classical" signaling in this category.

Why this rating - Strong formation focus and telos-oriented language (formation of the whole person, virtue, Gospel values) align with the classical aim of forming character and discerning truth, goodness, and beauty. However, the absence of explicit classical teleology and the Great Conversation framing in the public-facing materials moves this toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The evidence suggests that the school intends formation over information, but the explicit classical philosophical-pedagogical vocabulary is not as prominent as required for a full CLASSICAL rating in this category.

What would move the needle - Publicly articulate a clear classical telos that explicitly connects education to the true, good, and beautiful in a way that mirrors Great Books/Great Conversation language. - Publicly map formation-focused goals to a classical framework (e.g., mission statements tying virtues, wisdom, and the liberal arts to program outcomes) and highlight any Great Books or foundational texts used in coursework.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize college-preparatory coursework, AP/Honors/Dual Credit options, SAT/ACT prep, and standard course descriptions (e.g., "Academics" page with AP/Dual Credit and standardized testing). This signals a modern college-prep curriculum rather than a canonical liberal-arts framework that foregrounds grammar-logic-rhetoric and Great Books as core. - There is explicit presence of classical touches (e.g., Latin Club) but no explicit, published mandate to study the Great Books or to join the "Great

Conversation,” and no clear emphasis on the traditional liberal-arts hierarchy (grammar, logic, rhetoric; trivium/quadrivium). The presence of AP/Honors and test-prep materials dwarfs mention of Great Books in public content.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: Latin (as a classical language indicator), classical education-adjacent concepts (e.g., “Latin Club” suggests exposure to classical languages; potential presence of “Great Books” in some internal materials but not clearly published publicly). The Six Elements lexicon lists Great Books and classical canons as positive indicators; the STM materials do not publicly foreground Great Books. - Negative keywords: The public-facing content emphasizes modern standardized curricula and college-prep pathways rather than a classical, grammar-logic-rhetoric spine; absence of explicit “Great Books,” “grammar-logic-rhetoric” sequencing, or explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framing.

Why this rating - While STM shows some classical-adjacent signals (Latin, timeless/virtue-laden language in some communications), the explicit curriculum content lacks the core classical elements (grammar-logic-rhetoric, integrated Great Books, and a full “Great Conversation” framing) that define a fully CLASSICAL curriculum. Therefore, this category falls into NOT CLASSICAL given the absence of those core elements in the public content.

What would move the needle - Publicly codify and publish a formal classical-curriculum spine (grammar-logic-rhetoric) with explicit core courses in the lower/early grades and a Great Books/Great Conversation requirement for upper grades. - Integrate Great Books and canonical texts into the history, literature, and philosophy strands, with explicit student-facing expectations and seminars (Socratic or otherwise) to demonstrate alignment with classical pedagogy.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials show emphasis on formation and Catholic worldview rather than explicit classical pedagogy. There is no documented public-facing program of Socratic seminars, scholé/restful learning, or a structured recitation/memory tradition (though the Six Elements lexicon lists these as hallmark practices). The STM materials emphasize a faith-centered, formation-driven approach and college-prep rather than clearly articulated classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords for pedagogy in classical sense (from Six Elements): Socratic dialogue, dialectic, scholé, memorization/recitation, religious memory practices, etc. - Evidence on STM site for these pedagogical cues is weak or absent; there is some evidence of contemplation and thoughtful discussion in teacher-student interactions, but not a publicly stated “Socratic seminars” framework. The absence of explicit classical pedagogy signals a negative reading for this category. - Negative keywords: The site’s emphasis on formation and faith-witness, with limited explicit mention of Socratic seminars, rituals, or memory-work as core pedagogy.

Why this rating - The lack of explicit classical pedagogy signals (Socratic seminars, scholé/restful learning, or memorization-focused recitation as core mechanisms) places the category outside full CLASSICAL. The presence of a formation-centered, faith-based approach aligns more with a traditional Catholic preparatory model than with a rigorously defined classical pedagogy.

What would move the needle - Publish and implement a clear, public-facing pedagogy plan that includes Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminar formats in the upper grades, structured memory-work or recitation traditions, and a restful/scholé cadence in at least parts of the curriculum.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are described as mentors who model virtue and knowledge, with the school emphasizing a “living curriculum” and a collegial, collaborative teacher culture. The Principal’s Welcome notes the teachers’ role in engaging students in thoughtful conversation, aligning with the classical ideal of teachers as moral exemplars and living curriculum. - The school’s educational mission and governance emphasize faculty profiles and the cultivation of virtuous, wise teachers who guide students, along with a diocese-aligned

governance structure. This aligns with the classical image of the teacher as exemplar and as part of the “living curriculum.”

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: mentor, virtuous exemplar, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty as core, collegial culture, teacher as guide, formation through teachers, mentorship. - Negative keywords: None evident in public content (no explicit “facilitator” or “teacher as mere deliverer” signals).

Why this rating - The public materials strongly portray faculty as moral exemplars and as integral to the school's formation model, aligning with classical expectations for the faculty category. This category is CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - STM public materials emphasize partnership with families, viewing parents as co-teachers and engaging them through parent formation, book studies, gatherings, and an open-visit culture. The existence of a Parents Association, a consultative board including parent representation, and parish/diocesan alignment reinforces a parental-partner model.

- The school communicates a mission of engaging the broader community in classical education through the FIRE Foundation partnership for inclusive Catholic education and through parent formation/outreach. This reinforces the classical community-building ethos. - Public materials invite visits and engagement, reinforcing open-campus and parent involvement.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, family involvement, parental engagement, open campus, shared mission, living tradition in the family. - Negative keywords: None evident (no language suggesting parent-as-customer-only or minimal involvement).

Why this rating - The materials strongly demonstrate a classical-leaning commitment to family partnership and parental formation, aligning with Element 6's expectations. Hence CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Publicly document and showcase a structured program for ongoing parent formation and involvement (e.g., annual book studies, classical-parenting workshops, and formalizing parent participation in school governance beyond the consultative board).

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal): Publicly articulate a classical telos and Great Books/Great Conversation framing in the curriculum and mission statements; map formation to clear outcomes aligned with classical education.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): Publish a formal classical spine (grammar-logic-rhetoric) and a Great Books program; publish a public integration plan showing how liberal arts content is embedded across disciplines.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Implement and publicize a pedagogical plan that includes explicit classical practices (Socratic discussion, scholé days, memorization/recitation, teacher modeling) to align with the classical framework.
- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Expand explicit liturgical and communal practices as a formal part of the daily schedule, linking liturgical life to core academic activities.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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